

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Government and Public Administration English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For public administrators, agency program managers, policy analysts, procurement staff, constituent-service teams, grants managers, and interagency coordinators.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

allowable cost

An expense permitted under the rules or agreement governing a grant or program.

appeal

A request for a decision to be reviewed through an established process.

appropriation

Funding authorized for specified public purposes through the relevant budget process.

authority

The recognized power to decide, act, or provide an authoritative basis for a conclusion.

bidder

A person or organization submitting an offer in a procurement process.

casework

Work performed to help an individual navigate a service, issue, or administrative process.

conflict of interest

A situation where another interest may improperly influence a person's duties or judgment.

constituent

A person served or represented by a public official or institution.

data sharing

Making data available to another person or organization under appropriate conditions.

eligibility

Rules that determine whether a person, account, provider, service, or request qualifies for a program, benefit, or action.

equity

Fairness in access or treatment; in finance, ownership interest or residual value.

ethics

Principles and standards used to judge responsible conduct.

evaluation criteria

The stated standards used to compare or assess options or performance.

exemption

A defined exception to a rule or requirement under the applicable process.

facilitation

Guiding a discussion so people can contribute, understand differences, and reach useful next steps.

grant

Funding provided for an agreed purpose subject to stated conditions.

implementation

Putting an agreed plan, product, or process into operation.

jurisdiction

The legal authority of a court or public body over a matter or area.

memorandum of understanding

A document recording parties' shared intentions or arrangements; legal effects depend on its terms.

outcome measure

An indicator used to assess whether an intended result occurred.

owner

Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.

policy

Formal rule or standard that guides decisions and behavior.

procurement rule

A requirement governing how purchasing or supplier selection must be conducted.

public comment

Input submitted by members of the public in a defined consultation process.

public guidance

Official information explaining how a public program or process operates.

public record

A record held by a public body that is subject to applicable records rules.

public records

Records held by public bodies and governed by applicable access and retention rules.

public value

The benefit an activity creates for the community or people served.

reporting

Communicating required or useful information in a defined form or process.

RFP

Request for proposals: an invitation to submit an approach and offer for specified work.

stakeholder

Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.

subrecipient

An organization receiving a portion of an award to carry out part of a funded program.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Help a group reach a clear next step

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Policy Implementation and Program Rules

A resident mistakes draft eligibility guidance for a final rule. The office has published current guidance and a separate proposal.

The proposal is under review; the current published guidance remains the reference for today's process. Let me show you the distinction and where official updates will appear.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

02 | Public Meetings and Stakeholder Input

At a public meeting, two speakers use most of the time and several people have not been heard. The meeting has an announced participation process.

Let's return to the announced speaking process so more people can contribute. I'll summarize the points raised and invite the next speaker, while keeping the record clear about what remains unresolved.

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

03 | Procurement and Vendor Selection

A procurement evaluation note uses "best value" without linking the judgment to published evaluation criteria.

Which stated criteria support that assessment? Please connect the evidence to those criteria so the review explains the basis for the judgment rather than relying on a general label.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

04 | Grants, Compliance, and Reporting

A grant report contains a total expenditure figure but lacks the requested supporting categories.

Could you provide the category breakdown and supporting references required for this report? If an item is unresolved, please identify it so the grants team can explain the next step.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

05 | Interagency Coordination

Two agencies are coordinating a service request. Each assumes the other will contact the resident.

Could we confirm which agency will make the next contact and by when? I'll record that responsibility and the permitted information-sharing route so the resident receives a coordinated response.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

06 | Constituent Services and Escalation

A resident has been redirected between offices without an explanation of who can address the issue.

I'm sorry you have been redirected without a clear explanation. Let me identify the office with the relevant authority and confirm the next contact rather than send you on without that information.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

07 | Transparency, Records, and Ethics

A records request involves material that may require review for an exemption. An initial note says all material will automatically be released.

The request needs review under the applicable records process. I'll avoid promising a release decision before that review and explain how the office will communicate the outcome.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

08 | Performance Metrics and Budget Justification

A budget proposal lists activities delivered but does not show the intended public outcomes.

The activity count tells us what was delivered. We also need to explain the intended outcome and how it will be assessed. I'll connect the spending request to that public-purpose question.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.